



buzz



Robot fish for a green Earth

Scientists in the UK have deployed robotic fish in the seas of Spain, to detect pollution

The "Netbook" spat

Netbooks — the new segment of tiny laptops may be all the rage lately; but it turns out that the term *netbook* is actually owned by Psion Teklogix. This little known company had trademarked the term when it created the Psion Netbook handheld computer in the late 1990s. Based in Canada, it is facing litigation from giants such as Dell and Intel seeking to negate the trademark. Intel who has filed the most recent complaint argues that Teknologix no longer makes Netbooks and that the general public has accepted this word into its lexicon to describe the new breed of ultra-portable, inexpensive range of personal computers used to surf the net. Intel also claims that Psion lied in one of its statements to the Patents and Trademarks Office. On the Psion web site however, the Netbook Pro appears in the discontinued category.

The story doesn't end there though. Psion has also countersued Intel claiming that Intel's continued use of the word, dilutes the significance of Psion's own Netbook. It claims that the Netbook mark is recognised by the consuming public as something that relates to Psion. Highly doubtful. But let's see where this war of words ends up.

Free Gary

A self-confessed UK hacker Gary McKinnon has been embroiled in a long standing battle with the US government for hacking into around 90 of its military systems. For six years since his arrest in the UK, the case has been proceeding towards his imminent extradition to the US to stand military trial. Now it looks like it's finally coming to a close, with Gary being packed off to the US where he could face up to 75 years in prison. What makes this case different is that Gary, 42, is suffering from Asperger's Syndrome and claims he was looking for evidence of UFOs, which are commonly believed to be kept secret by the US govt. Several eminent personalities in the UK have come forth in support of the hacker to be tried in the UK itself, including Lord Carlile of Berriew and human rights campaigner Terry Waite. According to Waite, Garry is only being irrationally obsessive (which is a common symp-



tom of the disorder) about his belief in little green men and posed no threat to national security. In fact, he has only highlighted the vulnerability of the US defence systems. Perhaps a bit of common sense is required.

Nokia wants laptop pie

It really doesn't take a genius to figure that the laptop and mobile markets are going to converge somewhere in the not-so-distant future. Nokia seems to know this quite well, and has recently announced that it is actively looking at such an opportunity. Of course, this is all just internet buzz, but several reports claim that an announcement to this effect was made by Nokia CEO Olli-Pekka Kallalavuo to Finnish broadcaster YLE. There are other indicators too. The mobile giant's decision to launch a USB HSDPA 3G laptop dongle is one example. Besides, there is talk of Symbian on laptops too. The advantages? Since the OS is optimised for low-power consumption, there's the

promise of better battery life. But will it be able to take on the hardware in terms of drivers? Laptop users want to be able to attach and install a multitude of hardware devices to their machines. And what about the shoddy user interface of Symbian? Surely Nokia will put some R&D into improving that aspect. Besides, Nokia might actually come up with some nice looking laptops, since its phones have scored high on design so far. Also, leveraging its massive manufacturing capabilities, it can also compete on price. Let's keep an eye out, shall we?

Cover your tracks

Your late night surfing in the nefarious corners of the web can give you a shock when you face ads the next morning at your workplace. Google is testing a radically different approach at making ads more relevant to surfers. According to the new model, Google peeks into your history to throw up relevant ads when you show up on its sister sites — YouTube for example. According to Google, this gives more value to the advertisers, and the user gets more relevant ads. This model essentially tracks the behaviour of people before throwing up relevant ads, and is facing a mild backlash for being invasive.

Users can choose to disallow Google from tracking their movements on the web, and additionally, specify what kind of ads they want to see. A new tool called ads preference manager can be used to change the way these ads are displayed.

This tool allows you to specify categories of ads that you'd like to see, and even an option to disable those ads, which is not the same as disallowing Google from tracking you. Google's past run-ins with user privacy include personal pictures in Google Street View, the infamous 60-year cookie, and AdSense itself.

Debris to miss ISS

Space may be the final frontier, but what lies in between is a whole lot of junk. That's right — old obsolete satellites and other discarded orbital junk spin around the planet and it's getting crowded up there. Recently, a piece of a Russian satellite came within half a mile of the international space station (ISS). Mission controllers at the Johnson Space Center in Houston were considering evasive action, but ultimately the problem was solved itself. Latest tracking information showed that the piece of debris will narrowly escape, passing on the outskirts of a specified control



zone around the space station. "It's a very low probability of hit — less than one in 100,000", an official has said. Though this is not the first close call the space station has had in the recent past. Earlier, a piece of debris five inches across and coming from a rocket booster, came within three miles of the station. Since it was hurtling at 20,000 mph it posed a serious risk and forced the astronauts on board to take cover inside their escape capsules. Maybe an orbital clean up crew should be sent up there. Space trucking, anyone?

PC sales nosedive

Personal computer sales are expected to hit rock bottom during the year 2009. The global recession is causing dire market predictions from the top PC manufacturers. HP, Compaq and IBM have all predicted low sales. Sales dropped by 2 per cent over the last quarter of 2008, compared to the same time period a year ago. Dell was one of the few companies to show a rise in the number of units sold, but it too, has